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From Sindbad to Zheng He

At about the same time that Emperor Harsha was consolidating his empire and Xuan Zang was setting off on his long pilgrimage, a former merchant called Muhammad had set in motion a chain of events that would dramatically change the political and religious landscape of Arabia and eventually of the world. By the time Prophet Muhammad died in 632 AD, he already controlled much of the Arabian peninsula. However, within a century, his followers created an empire that stretched from the Iberian peninsula to Central Asia. In the eighth century, the Arabs established a toehold in Sindh by defeating Raja Dahir.

The Muslim conquest of Sindh, however, did not seem to have impacted the Indian heartland. Arab attempts at further expansion appear to have been fended off by the Rashtrakuta and the Gurjara–Pratihara kingdoms (the latter gave their name to the state of Gujarat). Arab chroniclers specifically wrote about the excellent quality of Indian cavalry. Indeed, the emerging Rajput military class appears to have made counter-raids of its own and much of Afghanistan continued to be ruled by the Hindu Shahis well into the tenth century. Thus, for the first several centuries of Islam, India’s interaction with Islam was defined not by conquest but by trade.

THE AGE OF SINDBAD

Arabs had been actively involved in trade with India from pre-Islamic times. In the early seventh century, the ports along the western coast were